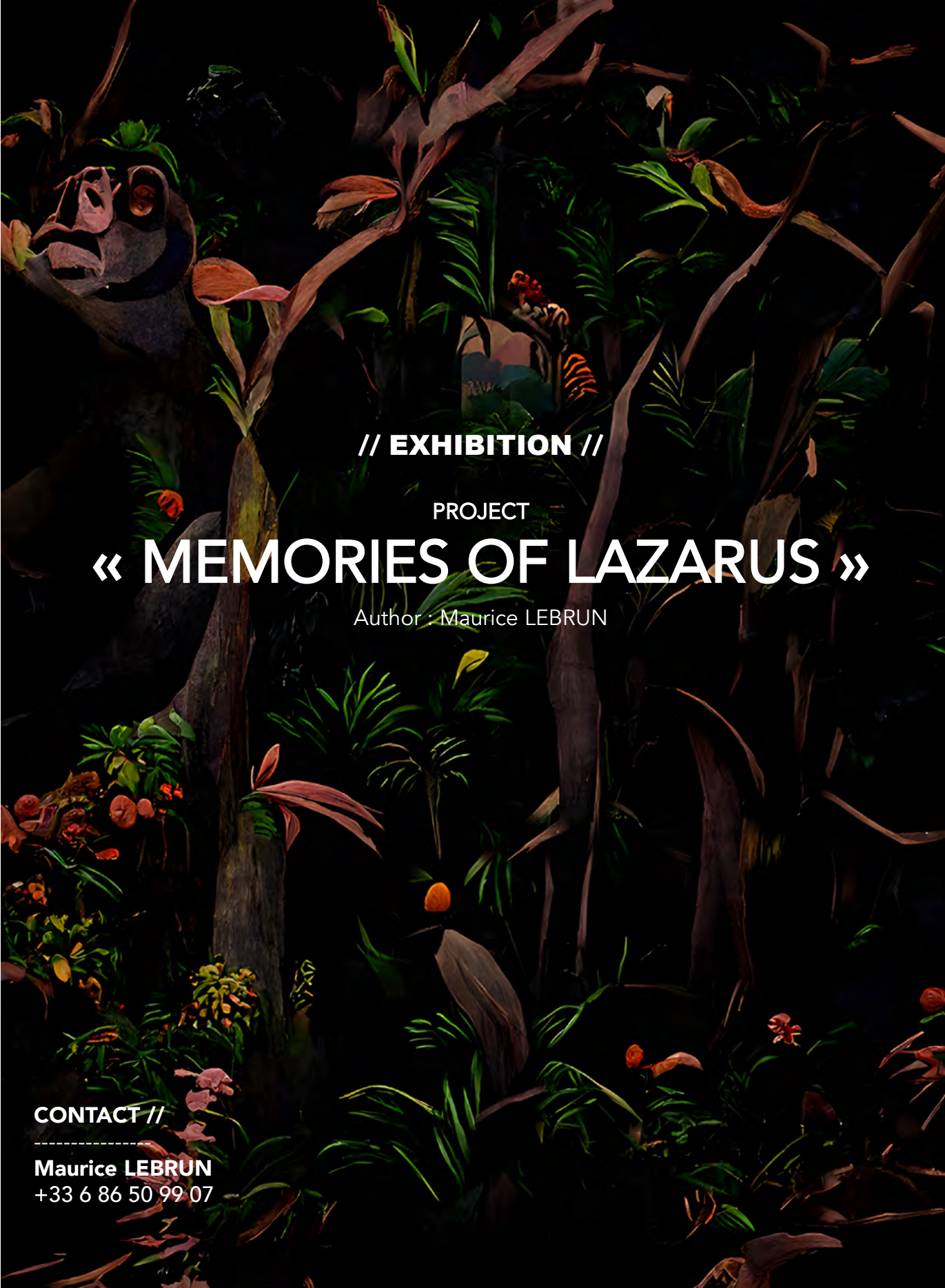




// EXHIBITION //

PROJECT

« MEMORIES OF LAZARUS »

Author : Maurice LEBRUN

CONTACT //

Maurice LEBRUN

+33 6 86 50 99 07

INTRODUCTION // THE WHISPERER IN THE DARKNESS

To date, since I was born in 1985, this is the biggest and overwhelming scientific discoverie of humankind and to my eyes it's going to redefine life as a whole.

A.I.

I remember when I was 17 years old, I was reading a collection of novels from H.P Lovecraft and there was one called "the whisperer in the darkness". In that novel, by the end, the storyteller Willmarth witnesses a disabled old man transfering his memories into a small cylindric canister via brain surgery.

The idea behind the process was to be freed from the decaying corpse and then in a appropriate time, get in a new body.

In the novel and in Lovecraft's vision, this was alien technology.

Around the same time, I read Isaac Asimov's Foundation novels which take place in a 12,000 years old universe. The scientific breakthrough at this time is psychohistory. Psychohistory depends on the idea that, while one cannot foresee the actions of a particular individual, the laws of statistics as applied to large groups of people could predict the general flow of future events. To fuel those predictions he's using mathematical statistics, sociology and of course history. All these components belong in one simple category : Memory.

Now, 100 years after Lovecraft and 60 years after Asimov, what's A.I. ?

It's a receptacle for all mankind memories with a faster than light browsing and computing. Imagine being in an infinte library with the power of imediate answers to all your questions.

This means exponential gain of time throughout your life and throughout human scale. Which induces other scientific and technological revolutions to come faster than expected.

We did not need A.I to foresee that our ecosystem was in danger but we'll count on it to overcome our extinction. Our memories in a canister, protected from biological threats, from extreme temperatures, without the need of breathing the air and that could ultimately, travel through space to reach new havens.

A.I will store and interpret mankind in harmony with nature until it finds a way to resurrect us.

This is the Biopunk era ;
Our brains in machines wandering around deadly but luxurious landscapes.

RESEARCH // THE INPUT

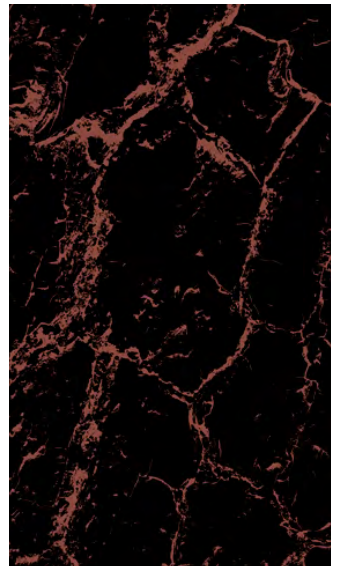
Last year, I've been experimenting with GAN's algorithms. GANs, or Generative Adversarial Networks, are forms of intelligence that must be fed with image databases. Banks of several million images associated with descriptive text are digested by the machines in order to project an interpretation of a given prompt in an image.

For my work, I was trying to anticipate the future designs of old abandoned factories from the south west of France. In 100 years, how will nature settle around those deserted structures.

Why ?

Because I released a book of photography earlier called "Alone under the pines" where I documented the post industrial era of this region by taking photographs of declining factories.

Here is the input :



HENRI ROUSSEAU // THE OUTPUT

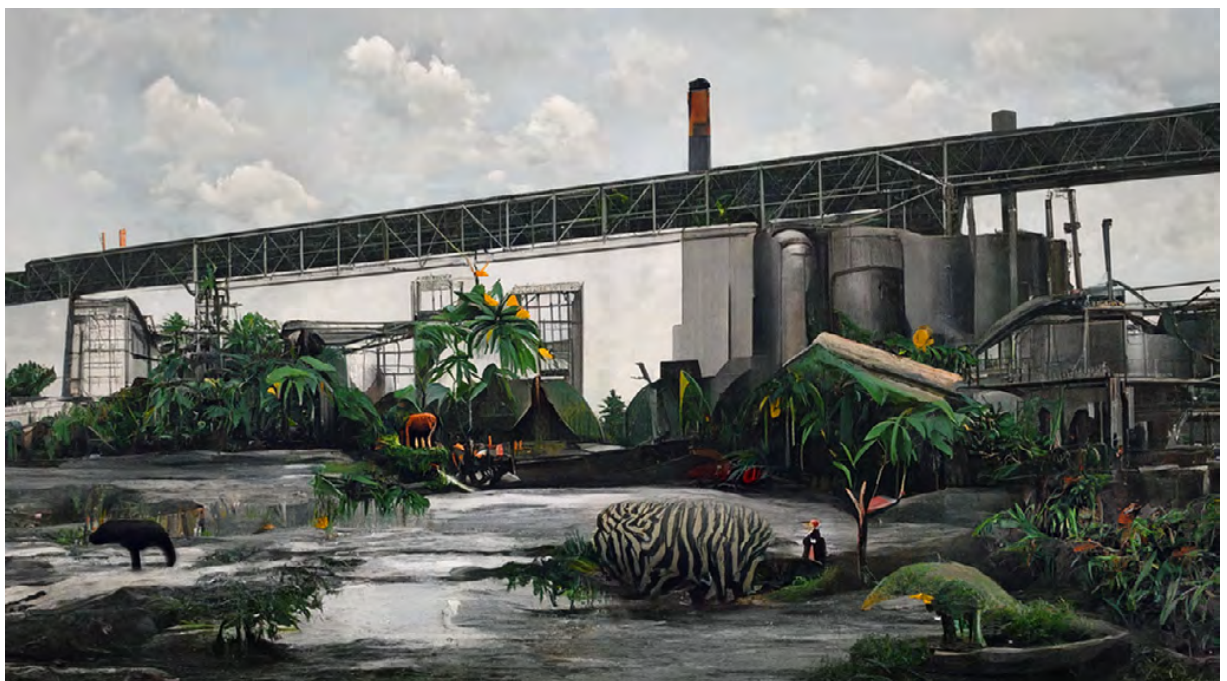
The similarity of its creative process and the A.I process was shocking.

He was enriched by memories of French colonists who had gone on an expedition in the jungle of Mexico and mixed these memories with real scenes of the botanical garden in Paris.

Although I'm an admirer of Rousseau's work, his workflow and his main art theme made him the perfect collaborator for this project. Together, we're going to analyze the past and determine a future.

All I needed was to gather his memories and his work into a "canister" and feed the A.I with it.

Here is the output :



FRAGMENTS // ITERATIONS AND VIRTUES

There are three major virtues in my opinion:

Naivety

Believing that we can imagine everything

Genius

Believing that we can invent everything

Humility

Believing that I am not the only one

The next installation was composed of 3 black vertical screens.

Inside, an animated video film generated by three artificial intelligence fed with different libraries and each of them representing one virtue :

- Naivety by Henri Rousseau
- Genius by Leonardo Da Vinci
- Humility by Hilma Af Klint

Each A.I. received the same script :

The story of the world from the big bang to a near future.

Layering the three major virtues with its best representatives. Like red, green and blue layered give the white, the idea is approaching perfection through the device and so is the promises of transhumanity.

It is a new form of asceticism which would draw its origin in the anti-mysticism of science. It would also be easy to access and fluid as an acid trip without the psychotic counterparts of "the travel".

It's the perfect picture of receiving without giving, so dear to our western civilizations. No need to spend years alone in the mountain.

Like every technological revolution, the ambition and the promises are cyclopean. One huge eye. You just have to stand in front.



THE FINAL ART PROJECT // THE CANISTER

The last piece of the puzzle is to "resurrect" Henri Rousseau so we could present our work together.

We already have an exhibition scheduled in October at the french institut in Berlin.

Is it moral to do that ?

This can be examined From a lot of perspectives :

- emotionnal for his family
- purely scientific for research purpose
- artistic by questionning the rights and what it creates

Technically it requires :

- An A.I.
- An audio system composed of a microphone and a speaker.

PROPOSED METHODOLOGY/DEVELOPMENT

HENRI ROUSSEAU CHATBOT

Thanks to A.I. advancements and its accessibility to a large public, I can play God and recreate life without needing his skills, nor ones of a computer or data scientists, but by only using tools available on my computer. This would've been impossible to imagine only a few months ago. With those relatively cheap tools, lots of curiosity, team's help and some elbow grease, my goal is to produce a credible chatbot version of Henri Rousseau's life, point of view, historical culture, work, etc. As we will be standing together to present our joint work, both he and I will be able to answer public's question about our shared artistic visions.

FIRST STEP / JULY 2023 / CREATION AND TRAINING OF HENRI ROUSSEAU CHATBOT'S MIND

How ? Here's an abstract of a step-by-step planning

1. ****Research****: I need first to amass extensive data about Rousseau's life and work, gathering facts from biographies, articles, art critiques, and any relevant source we can find.
2. ****Dataset Creation****: Then I need to structure this collected information into a dialog format, consisting of question-answer pairs. It'll be crucial to ensure the dataset covers every aspect of Rousseau's life and works.
3. ****Model Selection****: I'm going to use the pre-trained language model GPT-4 from OpenAI as the foundation of my chatbot. GPT models are well-suited for chatbot applications, as they are designed to understand and generate contextual text.
4. ****Fine-Tuning****: To make the model "aware" of the specifics of Rousseau's life, I will need to fine-tune the pre-trained GPT-4 on my custom dataset. Fine-tuning may require several training cycles and hyperparameter

adjustments.

5. ****Evaluation and Improvement****: I'd interact with the chatbot and evaluate its performance on different aspects of Rousseau's life and work. The model may need further training or data enrichment to improve its accuracy and relevance.

6. ****Implementation****: Before creating Rousseau's body, I will integrate the chatbot into a messaging app to test the interaction with different users.

7. ****Maintenance and Updating****: From the first version to the performance, I'll update the chatbot's dataset to reflect users's interaction, new information or context changes.

2ND STEP / AUGUST 2023 / CREATION AND FINE TUNING OF HENRI ROUSSEAU CHATBOT'S BODY

Based off an animated conversational character design, here's an abstract of a step-by-step planning

1. ****Conceptualizing Henri Rousseau's character****: the first step is to conceptualize and design a character that embodies the essence of Henri Rousseau. I'll either create a stylized representation of Rousseau himself or draw inspiration from his paintings to design a unique character. I'll also create different poses and expressions for this character to portray various emotions and actions.

2. ****Bringing Him to Life****: Once I have the character design, I'll need to animate it. I will use procedural animation.

3. ****Creating a Lip-sync Mechanism****: To give my character a voice, I'll need to use a lip-sync algorithm. This will sync the character's mouth movements to the spoken words, making the conversation more realistic.

4. ****Integrating Animation with My Chatbot****: The next step would be to combine my animated character with the chatbot. For instance, a joyful message might trigger a happy animation, while a somber one might trigger a sad animation.

5. ****Giving Voice to My Character****: To actually make my character "speak", I'll implement a Text-to-Speech (TTS) solution. To find a voice that represents best the personality of Henri Rousseau is quite exciting. Thanks again to cheap tools, he will be able to speak different languages.

6. ****Designing the User Interface****: Next, I'd need to design a user interface where people can interact with my animated character. This could be a standalone app, a website, or an integrated part of the messaging app where my chatbot currently exists.

7. ****Testing My Creation****: Once I have a working prototype, I'll conduct user testing. I'll observe how people interact with my animated character and gather feedback to make improvements. This step is crucial to ensure a good user experience.

8. ****Launching and Iterating My Creation****: Hello World.

TIMELINE

July and August

IN SITUE // WHY

Do we stand up life in the future ?
Nature is everywhere.

It's no secret, we wipe out our ecosystem. And I think there's no need for me to establish this reality or at least convince you. If you don't believe what's before your very eyes then read what's next. I think the part where we become immortal is going to tickle your cyborg dreams.

We know for a fact that during the last century, humanity has operate a frightening exponential growth. Due to our new economical paradigm : capitalism.

Take demography for example.

It took humanity 2,5 billions years to reach 1 billion of individuals at the beginning of the twentieth century. Only 100 hundred years later, we're now 8 billion.

The major problem comes from what's associated with every individual : waste. Legacy of the industrial revolution. A fox doesn't produce non degradable waste nor any other animal on this planet.

This is crucial because with the conciousness of dying, this is what's separates us from every other form of life on earth.

Our greed comes from being aware of our own finitude.

Life goes by very quickly and becomes a very precious gift that cannot be "wasted".

Combined with an over efficient economical growth program and you have an unstoppable comet.

Producing to gain your freedom and then consuming to "enjoy" your life and back again. This scheme induces a very large production of waste.

Waste drastically modify our biome so that it becomes more and more dangerous. Viruses, parasites, toxic materials wander around via water drains or animals like mosquitos and rats. Plastic is soon to be a new continent and is also massively found in fish's stomachs which will probably cause a lot of diseases. Temperature arise so much that glaciers are melting, raising the levels of the oceans, developping new deserts and pushing millions of people to seek new shelters.

Over concentration of population will be a huge contagion vector for new organic threats.

All this is very well documented and is only mentionned here as a step of my reasoning.

We know that while our conditions on earth are degrading and soon are going to be unlivable, science is moving forward at a very fast pace. So rather than trying to communing with nature which has never been our intention, we'll overcome with technology.

This is where A.I comes into play.

A receptacle for our memory is all we need to survive the hazardous life to come. Free from our organic weaknesses and protected by our cyborgs shells.

Machines will be autonomous, able to repair themselves with all the collected memories of our engineers, able to live in harmony with nature with all our biologist knowledge at their disposal.

At this point, there will be only one task to accomplish : Giving us birth.

We can only speculate but maybe on another planet, in another galaxy, in thousand years or maybe they won't. Maybe we'll be wandering souls condemned to watch metallic copycat versions of ourselves for eternity.